

What students told us

This document summarizes the interview patterns that shaped the team's original flexible meal-plan direction.

What we heard in the interviews

Students often said that a meal plan needs to feel worth the money. Their budgets and eating habits differed, but several concerns appeared across the interviews. Students did not want unused money to expire. They wanted flexibility in how they spent their balance and cared about having different food choices and dining locations.

The interviews also showed that one plan may not work for everyone. Some students preferred a dollar balance because their spending changes from day to day. Others preferred a set number of meals because it is easier to track. Reported semester budgets ranged from about \$400 to \$600 for some students and from about \$1,200 to \$1,500 for one student living on campus who expected to use the plan almost every day.

Our first idea: a flexible meal plan

The team selected a flexible campus meal plan for students with different budgets and eating habits. The idea included more than one plan level, rollover for unused value, and monthly or semester payment options. It rose above a single fixed plan because participants differed in how often they ate on campus and how they preferred to track spending.

Rollover was one of the strongest patterns in the interviews. Students repeatedly said that money or meals they had already paid for should not disappear when a semester ended.

How the interviews changed our thinking

The team stopped treating one fixed meal plan as the best option for every student. Commuters, students living on campus, and graduate students described different schedules and levels of use. The project shifted toward multiple plan structures instead of one universal plan.

The team also kept pricing, payment integrations, restaurant participation, and campus-wide implementation outside the first phase. The interviews supported further validation, but they did not prove that the university could implement every feature.

How we ran the interviews

The interview packet asked about recent dining experiences, spending habits, unused value, payment timing, food choices, and dietary needs. The team asked about past behavior rather than pitching a solution. It also recorded examples that did not support the proposed direction.

Participants were described without full names. The interviewer asked for verbal permission and did not record a conversation without consent.